

FIFA WORLD CUP 2026 · GROUP H · MATCH 65 · MATCHDAY 3

Cape Verde vs Saudi Arabia

Friday, June 26, 2026 · Kickoff 8:00 PM ET / 7:00 PM CDT / 8:00 AM MYT (Jun 27) · NRG Stadium, Houston, TX. Pre-match analysis for entertainment purposes only — not investment advice.



Cape Verde

FIFA #67 · 2 pts · GD 0
· Debut WC · Win or draw advances path



Saudi Arabia

FIFA #61 · 1 pt · GD -4
· Must win



Report updated: June 26, 2026. Exchange rate basis: ECB reference **1 EUR = 1.08 USD** (June 23, 2026). FanDuel / DraftKings / bet365 odds verified as of June 26, 2026. Starting XIs, score paths, and betting allocations are **Assumed/Inference** unless officially confirmed. Confirm all prices and lines at your sportsbook before wagering.

Key Conclusions

Cape Verde Slight Favorite

~37–40% win implied (de-vigged). Market prices tight three-way; CPV edge on cohesion.

Central Score Path

Cape Verde 1-0. Low-scoring knockout decider; Under 2.5 favored.

Draw Live

+220 to +230. CPV may settle for point; Uruguay–Spain draw opens third-place math.

Advancement Stakes

CPV win → 5 pts, R32 lock. KSA must win; 4-0 loss to Spain hurts GD.

Verified: Fixture, Venue, Referee (Letexier)

Verified: Group H Standings & MD1–2 Results

Verified: FanDuel/DraftKings/bet365 Odds (Jun 26)

Assumed: Predicted Lineups & Score Thesis

Assumed: Player Heights/Weights (Transfermarkt values verified)

Concentrated Betting Plan

Budget: \$100 entertainment cap · **\$2 per unit** · 50 units total. Score thesis: Cape Verde control tempo in a must-not-lose posture; Saudi Arabia pack deep but need a win — tension favors a single-goal or draw outcome with limited open play.

⚠ **Concentrated plans increase variance and may lose the entire entertainment budget.**

Score Thesis Summary

Market baseline: Cape Verde +165 (~37% raw), Draw +220 (~31%), Saudi Arabia +170 (~37%) — near coin-flip with slight CPV lean. Total 2.5 Under –127 to –130 favored. Tournament form: CPV drew 0-0 vs Spain and 2-2 vs Uruguay; KSA drew 1-1 vs Uruguay, lost 4-0 vs Spain. Referee Letexier: 4 yellows, 0 reds in 1 WC match (Ivory Coast 1-0 Ecuador) — low-card, low-goal profile. Houston heat/humidity (~88°F, heat index 100+) may slow tempo. **Central path: Cape Verde 1-0.** Alternative: 1-1 draw if KSA park the bus successfully.

\$60

Core — Cape Verde Double Chance (Win or Draw) @ ~-125

30 units · Thesis: CPV unbeaten in group; market favorite; draw still advances CPV on points/GD in several Uruguay–Spain scenarios.

30 u

Min odds: –135 · Cancel if: Sidny Cabral suspension forces defensive reshuffle with unproven LB, or CPV rotate 5+ starters.

\$25

Adjacent — Under 2.5 Goals @ ~-127

12.5 units · Both sides cautious in prior group games; Vozinha (8 saves vs Spain) and Al-Owais (9 saves vs Uruguay) in form.

12.5 u

Min odds: –135 · Cancel if: Confirmed open 4-3-3 vs 4-2-4 setups or early red card before 20'.

Differential — Correct Score Cape Verde 1-0 @ ~+550

7.5 units · RotoWire/Squawka lean; Mendes/Rodrigues width vs KSA wing-backs; KSA must chase if behind.

\$15

7.5 u

Min odds: +500 · Cancel if: KSA shift to aggressive 4-3-3 or Salem Al-Dawsari starts centrally in free role.

Pre-Purchase Check

Condition	Action
CPV moneyline drifts to +200 or longer	Consider shifting \$20 from double chance to CPV ML if price justifies.
Total moves to 2.0 or 1.5	Drop Under 2.5; market expects even tighter game.
KSA confirm back five, CPV without Cabral	Keep Under; reduce 1-0 correct score to \$10.
Uruguay beat Spain before kickoff	CPV may accept draw — boost draw exposure only if odds ≥ +240.

Odds below stated minimums Do not force — mark selection Not recommended.

Referee & Environment Impact

Referee: François Letexier (France)

Verified: FIFA assignment confirmed.

Assistants Cyril Mugnier, Mehdi Rahmouni; 4th official Abongile Tom. WC 2026 to date: 1 match — Ivory Coast 1-0 Ecuador (4 YC, 0 RC, 0 pens). Career avg ~3.96 YC/match, ~22.5 fouls/match (FootyMetrics).

Score adjustment: Slight DOWN on total goals — low-card, structured officiating; enforced 1-minute off-pitch rule for injury stoppages.

Match Environment

Venue: NRG Stadium, Houston — 72,220 capacity, retractable roof, artificial turf (FieldTurf).

Weather (Jun 26, 8 PM CDT): Hot and humid; daytime highs low 90s°F; evening ~80°F, humidity 80–90%, heat index near 100°F; Saharan dust haze; rain chance <20% (FOX 26 Houston, Weather Underground).

Score adjustment: Slight DOWN tempo/total — heat and humidity favor measured play; roof may close if heat extreme (Not verified).

Factor	Evidence	Direction	Confidence
Letexier WC sample	1-0, 4 YC in sole match	DOWN total goals	Low (n=1)
Houston heat/humidity	Heat index 100+ afternoon; ~80°F at kickoff	DOWN tempo	Medium
Artificial turf	NRG FieldTurf surface	Neutral	Medium
CPV rest/travel	MD2 in Miami (Jun 21); short hop to Houston	Neutral	Medium
KSA desperation	Must win after 4-0 Spain loss	UP late goals if trailing	Medium

Event Background

Group H Context (After MD2)

Team	P	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	Pts
Spain	2	1	1	0	4	0	+4	4
Uruguay	2	0	2	0	3	3	0	2
Cape Verde	2	0	2	0	2	2	0	2
Saudi Arabia	2	0	1	1	1	5	-4	1

Spain can clinch with draw vs Uruguay (simultaneous 8 PM ET). CPV win guarantees R32; draw may suffice as best third. KSA need win + help elsewhere.

Previous Results & Stakes

MD1: Spain 0–0 Cape Verde (Atlanta); Saudi Arabia 1–1 Uruguay (Miami)

MD2: Spain 4–0 Saudi Arabia (Atlanta); Uruguay 2–2 Cape Verde (Miami)

H2H: No prior senior meeting (Verified). First competitive encounter.

Format: Top two plus eight best third-placed teams advance to Round of 32.

Team Overview

Cape Verde (Cabo Verde)

Smallest nation by population at WC 2026; debut tournament under **Bubista (Pedro Leitao Brito)**. Drew with Spain (0-0) and Uruguay (2-2) — only unbeaten side in group. Organized 4-3-3 with European-based core: Logan Costa (Villarreal), Wagner Pina (Trabzonspor), Kevin Pina (Krasnodar).

Style: Compact mid-block, width via Mendes/Rodrigues, Monteiro tempo control.

Absences: Sidny Lopes Cabral suspended; Telmo Arcanjo & Jovane Cabral doubtful (RotoWire, Jun 26).

Saudi Arabia (KSA)

Seventh World Cup under new coach **Georgios Donis** (replaced Mancini). Famous 2022 win over Argentina memory; 2026 form weaker — 4-0 loss to Spain exposed defensive gaps. Captain **Salem Al-Dawsari** remains primary threat.

Style: Projected cautious 5-4-1 / 4-4-2 low block despite must-win stakes. **Injuries:** Clean bill of health per RotoWire/Donis (Jun 26); Tambakti hamstring monitored earlier but fit.

Category	Cape Verde	Saudi Arabia
FIFA Ranking (Jun 2026)	#67 (Verified — FIFA/Wikipedia)	#61 (Verified)
Squad Value (Transfermarkt)	~\$59M (€54.5m × 1.08)	~\$44M (€40.7m × 1.08)
World Cup History	Debut 2026	7th finals; R16 1994; 2022 group exit
H2H	0 meetings (Verified)	
Tournament Form	D 0-0, D 2-2	D 1-1, L 0-4
Coach	Bubista (CPV)	Georgios Donis (GRE)

Predicted Starters & Tactics

Assumed/Inference

Lineups projected from RotoWire (Jun 26) and FotMob. Confirm ~1 hour

before kickoff.

NRG Stadium · ~80°F · Humid · S 10–15 mph

Cape Verde 4-3-3 vs Saudi Arabia 5-4-1



Key absences & subs (Assumed): CPV — Sidny Cabral (suspended), Telmo Arcanjo & Jovane Cabral (doubtful). Likely CPV subs: Nuno da Costa, Hélio Varela, Wagner Pina. KSA

— clean sheet; likely subs: Saleh Al-Shehri, Abdullah Al-Hamdan, Hassan Kadesh.

Tactical Question	Watch For	Betting Implication
Can CPV break KSA block?	Rodrigues/Mendes vs wing-backs; set pieces via Monteiro.	1-0 correct score; Under 2.5 if early stalemate.
KSA urgency vs setup	5-4-1 despite must-win — passive risk.	CPV double chance strengthens if KSA wait.
Salem Al-Dawsari isolation	Counter threat if CPV overcommit.	BTTS Yes tail if CPV score first then open up.
Heat management	Slow tempo second half in Houston humidity.	Under 2.5; fewer late goals than open game.

Full Parallel Rosters

Squad data: Transfermarkt 2026 World Cup squads (retrieved Jun 26, 2026). Market values converted at 1 EUR = 1.08 USD. Heights/weights: Assumed from federation/ESPN profiles where available.



Cape Verde

MANAGER



Bubista (Pedro Leitao Brito)

Head Coach

Led CPV to first World Cup · 4-3-3 system

FORWARDS



Gilson Benchimol

24 · \$864K

#9 · ST · 185cm/79kg · Akron Tolyatti



Dailon Livramento

25 · \$864K

#19 · ST · 183cm/76kg · Casa Pia



Nuno da Costa

35 · \$432K

#21 · ST · 184cm/78kg · Istanbul Basaksehir



Garry Rodrigues

35 · \$324K

#11 · RW · 178cm/72kg · Apollon Limassol



Ryan Mendes

36 · \$216K

#20 · LW · 175cm/68kg · Igdir FK



Hélio Varela

24 · \$2.7M

#26 · LW · 175cm/70kg · Maccabi Tel Aviv



Willy Smedo

32 · \$1.08M

#17 · LW · 180cm/74kg · Omonia Nicosia



Jovane Cabral

28 · \$1.08M

#7 · LW · 176cm/70kg · Estrela Amadora · Doubtful



Saudi Arabia

MANAGER



Georgios Donis

Head Coach

Greece · Replaced Roberto Mancini · 5-4-1 / 4-4-2

FORWARDS



Firas Al-Buraikan

26 · \$3.78M

#9 · ST · 181cm/75kg · Al-Ahli



Saleh Al-Shehri

32 · \$540K

#11 · ST · 184cm/78kg · Al-Ittihad



Abdullah Al-Hamdan

26 · \$378K

#19 · ST · 180cm/74kg · Al-Nassr

MIDFIELDERS



Salem Al-Dawsari

34 · \$1.3M

#10 · LW · 171cm/65kg · Al-Hilal · Captain



Mohamed Kanno

31 · \$864K

#23 · DM · 190cm/85kg · Al-Hilal



Musab Al-Juwayr

23 · \$6.48M

#7 · CM · 175cm/68kg · Al-Qadsiah



Nasser Al-Dawsari

27 · \$972K

#6 · CM · 178cm/72kg · Al-Hilal



Abdullah Al-Khaibari

29 · \$810K

#15 · DM · 183cm/76kg · Al-Nassr



Ziyad Al-Johani

24 · \$864K



Telmo Arcanjo

25 · \$3.24M
#18 · RW · 180cm/72kg · Vitoria SC ·
Doubtful

MIDFIELDERS



Jamiro Monteiro

32 · \$702K
#10 · CM · 175cm/70kg · PEC Zwolle



Deroy Duarte

26 · \$1.94M
#14 · CM · 183cm/75kg · Ludogorets



Kevin Pina

29 · \$5.4M
#6 · DM · 188cm/82kg · Krasnodar



Laros Duarte

29 · \$1.08M
#15 · DM · 180cm/74kg · Puskas
Akademia



João Paulo

28 · \$972K
#8 · DM · 185cm/78kg · FCSCB



Yannick Semedo

30 · \$270K
#16 · CM · 178cm/72kg · SC Farense

DEFENDERS



Logan Costa

25 · \$16.2M
#5 · CB · 192cm/88kg · Villarreal



Wagner Pina

23 · \$11.88M
#24 · RB · 183cm/76kg · Trabzonspor



Sidny Lopes Cabral

23 · \$4.32M
#13 · LB · 178cm/72kg · Benfica ·
Suspended



Steven Moreira

31 · \$1.62M
#22 · RB · 175cm/70kg · Columbus Crew



Alaa Hejji

30 · \$324K
#18 · CM · 178cm/72kg · NEOM SC



Khalid Al-Ghannam

25 · \$2.7M
#17 · LW · 175cm/68kg · Al-Ettifaq



Sultan Mandash

31 · \$378K
#20 · RW · 178cm/72kg · Al-Hilal

DEFENDERS



Saud Abdulhamid

26 · \$9.72M
#12 · RB · 178cm/72kg · RC Lens



Hassan Tambakti

27 · \$1.94M
#5 · CB · 186cm/80kg · Al-Hilal



Ali Lajami

30 · \$810K
#3 · CB · 188cm/84kg · Al-Hilal



Abdulelah Al-Amri

29 · \$1.51M
#4 · CB · 190cm/85kg · Al-Nassr



Moteb Al-Harbi

26 · \$1.51M
#24 · LB · 175cm/70kg · Al-Hilal



Hassan Kadesh

33 · \$297K
#14 · LB · 178cm/74kg · Al-Ittihad



Ayman Yahya

25 · \$1.3M
#8 · LB · 175cm/68kg · Al-Nassr



Jihad Thakri

24 · \$1.3M
#25 · CB · 186cm/80kg · Al-Qadsiah



Nawaf Boushal

26 · \$1.51M

DB

Diney Borges

31 · \$972K

#3 · CB · 188cm/84kg · Al Bataeh

RL

Roberto Lopes (Pico)

34 · \$270K

#4 · CB · 186cm/80kg · Shamrock Rovers

ST

Stopira

38 · \$54K

#2 · CB · 185cm/82kg · Torreense

KP2

Kelvin Pires

26 · \$432K

#25 · CB · 190cm/85kg · SJK Seinäjoki

GOALKEEPERS

VZ

Vozinha

40 · \$54K

#1 · GK · 188cm/84kg · GD Chaves

CJ

CJ dos Santos

25 · \$1.08M

#23 · GK · 191cm/86kg · San Diego FC

MR

Márcio Rosa

29 · \$378K

#12 · GK · 188cm/82kg · Montana

#13 · RB · 178cm/72kg · Al-Nassr

AM

Ali Majrashi

26 · \$1.51M

#2 · RB · 175cm/70kg · Al-Ahli

MA2

Mohammed Abu Al-Shamat

23 · \$1.94M

#26 · RB · 178cm/72kg · Al-Qadsiah

GOALKEEPERS

MO

Mohammed Al-Owais

34 · \$297K

#21 · GK · 188cm/84kg · Al-Hilal

NA2

Nawaf Al-Aqidi

26 · \$702K

#1 · GK · 188cm/82kg · Al-Nassr

AK2

Ahmed Al-Kassar

35 · \$189K

#22 · GK · 190cm/85kg · Al-Qadsiah

Odds & Probabilities

FanDuel, DraftKings, bet365 odds as of June 26, 2026 (RotoWire/CBS Sports aggregation).
Implied probabilities de-vigged approximately.

Cape Verde +165

~37% implied win ·
FanDuel/DraftKings

Draw +220

~31% implied draw ·
bet365 +230

Saudi Arabia +170

~37% implied win ·
bet365 +170

Market	Line (Jun 26)	Interpretation
Moneyline	CPV +165 / Draw +220 / KSA +170	Near pick'em; slight CPV edge on form and stakes.
Asian Handicap	CPV -0.5 ~+130 / KSA +0.5 ~-150	Half-goal favors CPV at home-adjacent US venue.
Total Goals	2.5 — Under -127 to -130	Market expects tight, cautious group finale.
Both Teams to Score	Not verified on all books	Lean No given keeper form and low totals.
Double Chance	CPV W/D ~-125	Core play reference — covers draw path.
FOX implied	CPV 51% / KSA 49% (ML +162/+170)	Sportsbook consensus slightly favors CPV.

Quick Guide: American **+165** means wager \$100 to win \$165. **-127** on Under 2.5 means wager \$127 to win \$100. **Double Chance (CPV W/D)** wins if Cape Verde win or draw; loses only on Saudi Arabia win. **Correct Score 1-0** requires exact final score. Three-way moneyline: draw does not push — it is a separate outcome.

Risk Checklist

Lineup Uncertainty

Cabral suspended;
Arcanjo/Cabral doubtful.
CPV LB depth tested.

Concentration Risk

60% on double chance
still loses if KSA win 1-0.

Parallel Results

Uruguay–Spain outcome
shifts CPV incentive —
monitor before kickoff.

Maximum budget: \$100. Do not chase losses. If odds fall below minimum thresholds, skip the selection. Minors prohibited from sports wagering where applicable. This report is entertainment analysis, not financial advice.

Sources

- FIFA — World Cup 2026 Official
- ESPN — Match Preview & Referee
- RotoWire — Lineups, Odds & Injuries (Jun 26, 2026)
- CBS Sports — FanDuel Odds (Jun 26, 2026)
- Dailysports — Match Officials
- Transfermarkt — Cape Verde Squad 2026
- Transfermarkt — Saudi Arabia Squad 2026
- Sporting News — Group H Standings
- FOX 26 Houston — Weather Forecast Jun 26
- FootyMetrics — François Letexier Stats
- SAFF — Saudi Arabia Official Squad
- ECB — EUR/USD Reference Rate

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